



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 18

KENTUCKY

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Kentucky's family courts and child-welfare system.

52

KENTUCKY FAMILIES ON RECORD · 61
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 24 MONTHS
MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 20, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
10 OF 120

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

KENTUCKY AT A GLANCE.

Across 52 Kentucky families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 61 23 of 52 families reporting with kids	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$10,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 24 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 46.2% 28.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 52	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 2.7	REPORTING FAMILIES 23 of 52	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 10

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Kentucky families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF KENTUCKY FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	31	\$10,000	\$48,252	\$1,495,800
Lost Wages	24	\$12,500	\$53,054	\$1,273,300
Other Court Fees	22	\$900	\$7,964	\$175,200
Therapy / Evaluations	26	\$650	\$4,254	\$110,600
Reunification Services	16	\$450	\$1,275	\$20,400
GAL Fees	20	\$950	\$3,112	\$62,250
Asset Loss ¹	25	\$20,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$45,450	—	—

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$20,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		24	2 yrs
Mean months lost		41	3.4 yrs
Total across all families		1,344	112 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · KENTUCKY

Most families documenting in Kentucky are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Currently involved / "S...		17	33%
Case closed (more tha...		6	12%
Case closed (within th...		6	12%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and ...		30	58%
Family Court Only		11	21%
CPS (Child Protective ...		2	4%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		11	21%
Over 10 years		8	15%
3 – 5 years		8	15%
Less than 6 months		6	12%
5+ years		6	12%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Los...		24	46%
50/50 Joint		9	17%
Visitation Only		7	13%
Children in Foster Care		5	10%
Full Custody		3	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Jefferson		4	8%
Franklin county and M...		2	4%
Breckinridge		2	4%
Marshall		2	4%
Pulaski		2	4%
Spencer		2	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Acc...		13	25%
False Accusations CPS...		11	21%
Other: (Short answer)		7	13%
Child Protective Servic...		5	10%
High Conflict Divorce		3	6%

05 PARENT VOICES — KENTUCKY

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



They have destroyed my children and family. They almost took my and their father's life

— PAMELA

Mentally and emotionally destroyed me, taken my freedom as a parent away, destroyed my children's childhood and future

— JASON

This system has destroyed the lives of me and my children. My children currently live with their abusive father and I have no contact.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Absolutely devastated my children and I, separating and alienating us. Trying to cripple our bond and my children now suffer from severe separation trauma and more abuse by their fathers and wives

— HEATHER

Protected my abuser while causing me and my children more trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system ruined my life and stole my relationship with my children, completely

— KEVIN

“The system has emotionally drained us.” The system took my baby when I fought so deeply.”

— TRAVONNA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My daughter is traumatized Omy whole family is, she believes shes never coming home and wants to give up

— VELENA

It makes me wonder if my kids are even mine. Where is the accountability for family court actors?

— KAYCEE

They destroyed me and my family

— DANNY

Tore our family apart. Broken our children

— ASHLEY

Destroyed us, mentally, emotionally & financially!

— BRITNY

This wicked system has stolen something priceless that my son and I can never get back. It has inflicted trauma and irreparable harm for no legitimate reason. This injustice is inhumane.. we feel like we are in the twilight zone.

— EMILY

‘Through prolonged delays, silenced voices, blocked access to the courts, and unchecked power, the system dismantled our family not by justice, but by process—leaving my children separated and a parent unheard.’

— JESSICA

The Family Court has destroyed my entire life, separated me from my children and I was their primary caregiver, litigated me into destitution and I am at imminent risk to lose my home from delays and stalling. The judge is incompetent. Opposing counsel is now an accomplice- if [...]

— JENIFER

It has caused severe trauma and loss, emotionally and financially for my family. The excessive stress has also manifested as physical illness.

— VIVIAN

The system ruined my life and stole my relationship with my children, completely

— KEVIN

The system has failed ne and my family and most of all failed my kids

— JASON

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They never not once helped us like they promised they just took my baby out of my loving home, I was a good mom and brandy day the dcbs worker was childish she argued with the child's father and she did not like us period

— TRAVONNA

Alienation of the children from a loving father and stepmother

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Im still in therapy. Now in spravato and emdr, my youngest has abandonment issues and major anxiety, now pooping his pants, he has major separation anxiety from me. My older sons were completely brain washed. My ex now has control over their minds as well as they are very [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Traumatized my kids, their therapist stated she needed to teach my 10yo to be a survivor, to be able to survive the abuse by his dad bc the court keeps giving him unsupervised visitation. Medical issues, anxiety, ptsd, issues with schools that were supposed to be their safe [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My children have intentionally and forcefully been neglected and abandoned by removing me from their life.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Severed what was a strong bond between my children, myself, and my fiancéeI. Prevented healthy discussion and understanding for my kids to understand that they were not abandoned by me and that this is not a reflection of their worth.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Stole precious time, created permanent psychological scars that can heal but will never go away, and completely broke our trust in the government.

— DEIDRA

Tore us apart forever

— RICHARD

Destroyed my relationship with my children, used me for title four funding as a baby, then targeted my children because they knew I had no family. My six year old daughter (who i am just fine to parent) doesn't know her siblings, and they have been turned against me. Its like [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Cause great damage. These people do not know what they are doing....

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed. My sons are now brainwashed and alienated from me when I was the one accused of coaching and alienating them from their father because the didn't want to live with him.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

scared our minds forever,family problems with inlaws too much too list

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has accepted my ex wife's EPO against me for her and the children that was written in retaliation for me being done with her after 17 years of trying. It's been 8 months of the system separating me from my 5 children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my relationship with my children, used me for title four funding as a baby, then targeted my children because they knew I had no family. My six year old daughter (who i am just fine to parent) doesn't know her siblings, and they have been turned against me. Its like [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

removed me from my children's daily lives during the exact years their clinical records now show caused them measurable, documented harm: separation trauma, maximum-score separation anxiety, and a mood disorder diagnosed by two independent licensed clinicians who both concluded [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We r living in family court hell

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Withheld granddaughter from her family other sister because of lies. Wouldn't let granddaughter be with her sister because I (grandmother) exposed cps 2 years sooner .

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Tore us apart forever

— RICHARD

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

No steps towards reunification with my children despite completing my case plan for over a year. Visits have stayed at minimum since they were taken 2 hours every other week, I've requested increased visitation and in-home visitation supervised or unsupervised. Called urgent [...]

— SARAH I

37 Kentucky parents submitted ranked quotes. 37 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/ky.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Kentucky report comes from Kentucky respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Kentucky — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 52 Kentucky families reporting here are not the universe of Kentucky families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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